

Evolving with Responsive Design

>Responsive design is a popular term among web designers these days. What does it really mean, and why is it important? We hope to answer those questions and more> by Kshitij Sobti

A common property attributed to responsive design is the ability to resize columns and reorganise content structures based on the form factor of the device screen. Effectively, a three-column website could switch to two-columns when viewed on a tablet, or single column on a smartphone.

What is responsive design?

There is a vast spectrum of devices available these days and can range from a 3-inch mobile to a 60-inch TV set. Be it mobiles, tablets, netbooks, laptops, desktops, or televisions; most of these devices have browsers.

Responsive design is about understanding and responding to each of these devices. For example, mobiles and tablets essentially being touch devices, wouldn't benefit from fancy hover effects. TVs, on the other hand, are a beast of their own, and care needs to be taken to ensure that text is readable on screen, considering it is likely being viewed from a distance. Another factor that needs to be considered is data consumption on slower devices, especially GPRS and EDGE devices compared to a broadband-enabled device.

Conceptually, responsive design is similar to progressive enhancement, where you keep in mind the users who have the oldest browsers and computers, design their experience and ensure that it works. Then on top of that you can layer enhancements that make the site better for those who are accessing the website from a modern browser and modern machines in a less restrictive environment.

With responsive design you take into account the most basic experience of your website—which will likely be designed for mobile consumers—and you enhance that with more information, and features as the device gets more powerful and large.

Responsive design is more than just layout and screen size; it's also about bandwidth and device capability. A good example would be an article on the subject of the Eiffel Tower. For readers viewing the article on a desktop with a large monitor, you could have a nice wide header image with the Eiffel Tower. However if you were to simply resize the image for a mobile user, the results aren't very good—the tower is barely visible. A good responsive site would have an appropriate image rather than just a resized one.

So Responsive Design isn't about creating a different experience for each possible device, but to make your design flexible enough, and adaptable enough, that it can respond to any kind of device it is accessed from.

Why is adaptive design important?

This is a simple one. Because being considerate is important, simply because giving your viewers the best experience possible on the device they're using is *the* right thing to do. Responsive design in the end is about responsible design.

Let's make an analogy that puts this in "real world" terms. Imagine you go to a restaurant that has seating for groups of four. If you come with any fewer or more than four people, they refuse to serve you. You wouldn't be very happy would you? On the other hand, they could be responsive to your needs, by adding seats to the side if there are up to six people, or joining tables to accommodate more people. If you're annoyed that this has nothing to do with the web, we will have you know the waiter was noting orders on a web app running on an iPad — there, happy?

Similarly, no one likes to visit a website where they have to scroll horizontally on their mobile in order to read stuff. Or where the website uses huge images that make it load slowly on a mobile connection. People don't like mobile-centric experiences on their desktops either. They won't like it if your images look like crap because they were created for a smaller screen and navigation will be cumbersome. If you don't care about mobile web consumers, start now. It's

